

Step-by-step guide for ending manipulative friendships while protecting mental health and setting boundaries — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

IDENTIFY MANIPULATION TACTICS

- ☐ **Identify Manipulation Tactics:** Name the specific tactics being used against you —whether it's DARVO, guilt-tripping, silent treatment, or threats of self-harm—so you can see them clearly instead of doubting yourself.
- ☐ **Identify Manipulation Tactics:** Pinpoint which manipulation tactics have been used most frequently on you so you can anticipate when they're about to be deployed against you.
- ☐ **Identify Manipulation Tactics:** Notice when the manipulation escalates, which typically happens right when you're trying to pull away, so you can prepare for the hardest moments.
- ☐ **Identify Manipulation Tactics:** Track how you've automatically responded to each manipulation tactic so you understand exactly where your vulnerability points are.

UNDERSTAND YOUR TRIGGERS

- ☐ **Understand Your Triggers:** Name your specific triggers that make you want to reach out even when you've mentally decided the friendship is over.
- ☐ **Understand Your Triggers:** Identify the physical sensations in your body when guilt or fear spikes so you can recognize when your nervous system is being hijacked.
- ☐ **Understand Your Triggers:** Recognize how threats of self-harm create a hostage situation that makes you feel responsible for protecting someone who is manipulating you.
- ☐ **Understand Your Triggers:** Notice the pattern of unpredictable warmth followed by coldness that has created a neurological attachment stronger than consistent reward would have.

PREPARE YOUR EXIT PLAN

- ☐ **Prepare Your Exit Plan:** Build a set of regulation tools to use when guilt or fear spikes hit so you don't have to rely on willpower alone during the exit.
 - ☐ **Prepare Your Exit Plan:** Create crystal-clear boundaries about what you will and will not accept before you begin the exit process so you have something to refer to when pressure mounts.
 - ☐ **Prepare Your Exit Plan:** Develop a specific exit plan tailored to your situation that accounts for your particular triggers rather than using a generic script or template.
 - ☐ **Prepare Your Exit Plan:** Decide in advance how you will handle threats and when you will block or fade, prioritizing your own safety over maintaining access for the toxic person.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.